

LOCAL NEWS JUNE 20, 2014

Library Column: Communities and staff support our libraries



George Williams



George Williams Associated Press

The Latah County Library District consists of the headquarters branch in Moscow plus the Bovill, Deary, Genesee, Juliaetta, Potlatch and Troy branches. When I came here in 2006, after working for the Boise Public Library, what I found amazing then, and still find amazing now, is the number of libraries we are able to operate on such a small budget because, when I was at BPL, the city of Boise only operated two libraries and a bookmobile on a budget approximately seven times larger than our budget for seven libraries.

One of the biggest reasons we're able to operate so many libraries is because our local cities offer us a great deal of support to help us keep our branches open. For one thing, the Potlatch library building is the only building the library district owns. The branches in Bovill, Deary, Genesee, Juliaetta, Moscow and Troy are owned by those cities and leased to the library district for next to nothing. And, while we do own the Potlatch library building, the grant that allowed us to build that library in 1998 was a joint effort of the city of Potlatch, the Potlatch School District and the Latah Library District. Most of our communities help support the Library District by paying for utilities, fixing leaky water heaters, providing snow removal, changing burnt out light bulbs in very high ceilings, providing janitorial services and just generally being involved and offering help whenever possible. All of our communities love their branch libraries, and city government in Latah County does a lot to help us keep all seven of our branches open.

Another thing that makes us successful is we have a great staff. We couldn't begin to operate seven libraries spread out across a 1,000-square-mile county without our very dedicated staff. Our branch managers are only part-time employees but they are all engaged fully with their respective communities. Likewise, the staff who work at the Moscow branch are highly dedicated to helping patrons with library services. Whether they are employees who work at the circulation desk and are primarily responsible for helping people in Moscow or the administrative staff who have responsibilities that affect all of our locations, the staff at the Moscow branch are very committed to helping patrons in Moscow and throughout the entire library district.

One of our staff members was Paula Winter, who died earlier this month. Paula began working at the Bovill branch in the summer of 1997 and became the branch supervisor of that library in the fall of 2001. I only had the opportunity to

work with Paula for about four years, which was far too short a time. Whenever I went to the Bovill branch, no one came into the library that Paula wasn't on a first name basis with. Paula was always friendly, knowledgeable and happy to help anyone with questions about the library. She was equally happy just to talk with anyone who came into the library and listen to their concerns about the library, Bovill, picking huckleberries or whatever else they wanted to talk about. Her work, friendliness and kind nature helped make the Bovill branch library the important part of the community that it still is today. I know Paula did not wish to leave her job at the Bovill branch but, due to fragile health, she left that position in the spring of 2011. Paula will be greatly missed by her family, her friends and by supporters of the library in Bovill and throughout the county.

Although we will all miss Paula, her death reminds me I should take the time to thank my co-workers for all of the work they do in helping make it possible for us to have a successful library district in Latah County. So I'll also encourage all of you to do the same. The next time you're in your local library, be sure to thank library staff for all the work they do. And be sure to thank members of your city government for all the support they give the library district too. Without the support we receive from city government, library staff and all of our patrons, we would have a much more difficult time keeping all seven of our branches open.

George Williams is the access services manager for the Latah County Library District.

STORY TAGS

Libraries

